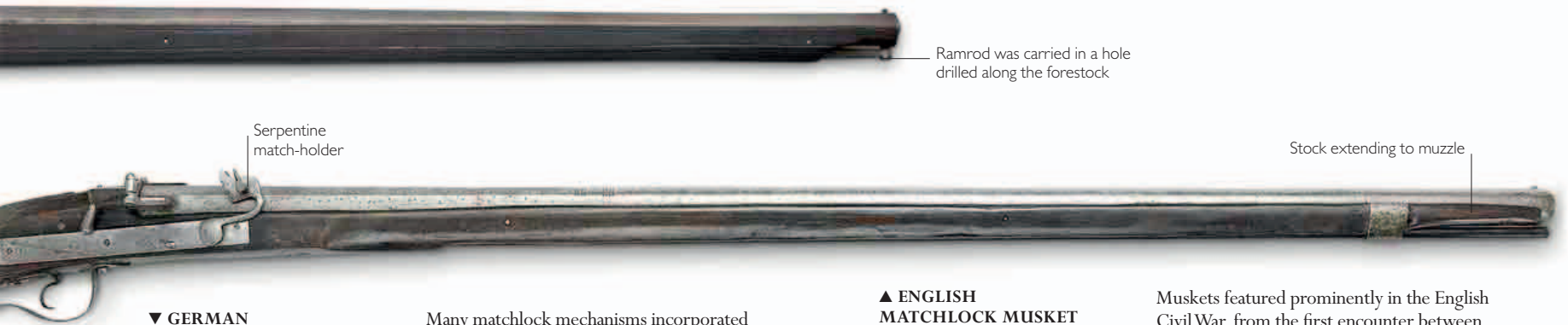




▼ GERMAN MATCHLOCK MUSKET

Date c.1580

Origin Germany

Barrel 46in (116.8cm)

Caliber Not known

Many matchlock mechanisms incorporated a simple lever, like that on early crossbows. The lever was squeezed to move the serpentine holding the smoldering match-cord into the priming pan. The military musket shown here is typical of those used in Germanic countries in the late 16th century.

▲ ENGLISH MATCHLOCK MUSKET

Date c.1640

Origin England

Barrel 45½in (115cm)

Caliber .73in (18.7mm)

Muskets featured prominently in the English Civil War, from the first encounter between Royalists and Parliamentarians at Edgehill in 1642 to the war's conclusion at Worcester in 1651. Because matchlocks took so long to load, musketeers were vulnerable, particularly to cavalry, and had to be protected by pikemen.



▼ HI NAWA JYU

Date 17th–19th century

Origin Japan

Barrel 36¾in (93.7cm)

Caliber .59in (15mm)

The *hi nawa jyu* was introduced to Japan by the Portuguese from their base in India in 1543. Within 25 years, manufacturing centers were producing thousands of these guns for arming foot soldiers, and the matchlock had become a decisive weapon in battle.



▲ DUTCH COMBINATION LONG GUN

Date 17th century

Origin Netherlands

Barrel 46in (117cm)

Caliber .90in (23mm)

This unusual musket is equipped with both a flintlock (see pp.38–39) and a matchlock mechanism. The matchlock pan is part of the top of the frizzen (pan cover combined with a striking steel). The matchlock is operated by the trigger guard, while the operation of the flintlock is by means of the trigger.



▲ BRITISH MATCHLOCK

Date 17th century

Origin England

Barrel 46in (117.2cm)

Caliber .70in (18mm)

By the end of their period of dominance, the best matchlocks had acquired a degree of sophistication, at least in their finish. They had also become much lighter, and thus were considerably easier to handle. A high-quality piece such as this would have been a prime contender for conversion into a snaphance (see p.38) or flintlock (see pp.38–39), had it not been preserved in a collection.